

Behind the Scenes: A SIG on Researcher Care and the Invisible Care Work

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Abstract

As CSCW research increasingly engages with communities, sensitive topics, and participatory methods, the emotional and ethical labor carried by researchers demands greater attention. While care ethics, affective labor, and feminist methodologies have gained ground within CSCW, conversations around *researcher care* remain limited and often informal. This SIG will explore the challenges and support needed to undertake emotionally demanding research journeys, particularly given the increasing distress and conflict in the global geopolitical landscape. We invite researchers to reflect on and share practices, challenges, and imaginaries of care for ourselves and our collaborators, alongside our participants. By underscoring the importance of researcher care and fostering a supportive network, this SIG aims to strengthen the resilience of the CSCW community.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

Keywords

Researcher care, emotional wellbeing, emotionally demanding research, care infrastructures

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1 Background and Motivation

“Research in a context that is emotionally sensitive for participants is also sensitive for the researcher—putting both participants and researchers at risk” — Chancellor et al. [4]

The CSCW community focuses on fostering technology-mediated collaboration, often spanning geographical, cultural, and institutional boundaries. Undertaking such research works frequently involve deep, sustained engagement with communities such as gig

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workers, caregivers and patients, educators, etc. (e.g., [2, 8, 14]), taboo topics (e.g., [13, 19]), sensitive and conflicted contexts (e.g., [7, 22]), and others. Ethical practices have long been the cornerstone of this work, with a strong emphasis on safeguarding the care, agency, and comfort of participants, ensuring that studies prioritize minimizing harm and *protecting the wellbeing of those involved*. At the same time, collaborating across teams, disciplines, and communities, particularly on sensitive topics or with vulnerable populations, can be emotionally demanding for researchers. It might entail encountering trauma, systemic inequities, and ethical dilemmas, navigating all of which involve a hidden layer of care work and emotional labor at the researcher's end and could contribute to secondary trauma [1, 18, 23]. As Toombs elaborates, “researchers take on additional roles, such as confidant, advocate, interloper, invader and collaborator [...] friend, validator, caregiver and—importantly in this case—care receiver and vulnerable other” [18]. This care work spans the entire research lifecycle, from study conceptualization and design to post-publication activities, yet it frequently remains invisible and undocumented within the field [24]. Here, it is important to reflect on how care ethics, affective labor, and feminist HCI are increasingly shaping conversations within the CSCW community (e.g., [9]). Expanding these conversations to explicitly include researcher care—not just care for users or participants—would strengthen the community's values and research practices. Caring for ourselves and one another is not separate from the work we do; it is integral to the way we work as a community.

There have been crucial albeit nascent efforts within the HCI community to bring attention to researcher care under themes such as “sensitive HCI” [23], emotion work [1], care ethics [18], stigma research [10, 20], and emotionally demanding research [5]. These efforts, in the form of workshops and courses, aimed at developing support materials [4–6, 16, 24]. More recently, the CSCW community has also begun to center these conversations. Examples of this are a recent CSCW 2025 paper focused on researcher wellbeing and a CSCW 2024 workshop titled “Caring for Reproductive Justice: Design in Response to Adversity”, which explored the challenges and costs of conducting such research amidst the prevailing volatile geopolitical landscape [9]. At the CSCW 2024 workshop—organized and attended by several authors of this SIG—the urgency to consolidate knowledge and resources for researcher care resurfaced.

Building on this momentum, as organizers and as CSCW and HCI researchers with lived experiences of undertaking emotionally demanding research journeys (e.g., [3, 9, 11, 12, 15, 20, 21]), we seek to hold a Special Interest Group (SIG) at CSCW 2025 to collectively reflect: **Do we need additional sustained efforts to advance researcher care as both a practice and a shared concern within the community? And if so, what form should these efforts take—community infrastructure, policy, or perhaps just a collated living repository of shared resources?** Through this initiative, we aim to foster a deeper collective understanding of care practices—at individual, interpersonal, institutional, and community levels—that support researchers engaged in emotionally demanding work. We also seek to envision community infrastructures cherishing researcher wellbeing and cultivating solidarity, reminding us that *we are not alone in this journey*.

2 SIG's Goals

The SIG aims to bring researchers and practitioners at CSCW together to continue the dialogue, foster shared learning, and promote reflexive practices centered on researcher care—emphasizing *caring for the self* as equally vital to caring for others—the participants and their communities—in emotionally demanding research. Through this exchange, we aim to sustain the growing dialogue on self-care practices, while laying the groundwork for future design practices, methods, and approaches to better support researchers. Together, we aim to:

- **Collate Shared Struggles, Values, and Strategies:** Surface common challenges and struggles researchers encounter during emotionally demanding research journeys, along with the shared values, and strategies they employ to care for themselves throughout the research lifecycle, from conceptualization to dissemination.
- **Revisit and Expand Definitions:** Reassess and broaden the understanding of what constitutes emotionally demanding research and invisible care work, recognizing its evolving nature in diverse research contexts.
- **Imagine Emerging Landscapes:** Discuss how emotional labor may evolve amid emerging and disruptive geopolitical, socio-cultural, and technological landscapes, towards preparing researchers for future complexities.
- **Collectively Envisioning Researcher Care Infrastructures:** Collaboratively explore potential infrastructures (e.g., strategies and resources) and initiatives to centralize researcher care, aiming for sustainable, community-supported solutions that integrate researcher wellbeing alongside participant care.

3 Proposal and Technical Requirements for SIG

The SIG aims to converge the conversations from the past workshops hosted at CHI 2017, 2019, 2022, and CSCW 2024, by inviting a broader audience for a round table discussion, addressing the growing challenges of conducting emotionally demanding research amid the evolving and increasingly tense global geopolitical landscape. These challenges transcend any single research domain within the CSCW and HCI community. Researchers navigating them bring diverse disciplinary expertise, varying levels of experience and representation across multiple subdomains. Bringing them together in a 90-minute session offers a unique opportunity to brainstorm, share insights, and collectively reflect and co-envision infrastructures for researcher care towards supporting emotionally demanding research journeys. Below is an informal outline of the SIG session:

- **Welcome and Introduction (10 min.):** We will begin with a brief welcome, introduce the SIG organizers, and provide an overview of the session's goals and structure.
- **Group Activity (30 min.):** Participants will form groups of 3–6 to identify, project, and map challenges encountered in conducting emotionally demanding research. Following this, each group will reflect on how these challenges might be reimagined: not as anomalies to overcome, but as values (e.g., slowness, expression, reflexivity, transparency) that should guide our research practices centering care for both the self and the others.

- *Group Report-Back (15 min.):* Each group will briefly share their insights with the larger gathering.
- *Plenary discussion and closing (35 min.):* We will then come together as a full group to reflect on the values surfaced and collaboratively envision what sustained efforts—whether infrastructural, policy-driven, or community-led—are needed to foreground these values as core practices and shared responsibilities within the CSCW community. We will also discuss the next steps for the SIG.

To prioritize accessibility, we will provide materials in multiple formats (e.g., paper and digital), ensuring the space is wheelchair accessible, and offering directions to quiet rooms for attendees who would like to step away from the session. We propose leveraging tools like Post-it notes, Miro, and Google Doc to collate and document co-constructed knowledge. Inspired by previous community infrastructure-building efforts (e.g., [17]), we aim to share the co-created knowledge publicly accessible to support future research. During the SIG, we will collectively determine the best medium(s)—such as a Miro board, Google Document, website, or publication—for this purpose.

The SIG's primary goals are to foster a sense of community among researchers undertaking emotionally demanding research journeys, collate and develop community care practices, and build support infrastructures that nurture researcher wellbeing. Post-SIG, depending on attendee interest, we plan to organize periodic meetings (or nurture similar interactive spaces) to provide a space for sharing current challenges, exchanging self-care practices, and seeking collaborations. Specifically, we envision these meetings as a focused effort to conceptualize, develop, and sustain community-driven care infrastructures (e.g., repository of shared knowledge and self-care practices), fostering researcher wellbeing and firmly establishing researcher care as a key agenda within the broader community.

4 Organizers

As organizers, we bring extensive experience conducting emotionally demanding research across diverse subdomains and methodological trainings, allowing us to bring a rich diverse of perspectives to this SIG.

Anupriya Tuli is a Digital Futures Postdoc at KTH Royal Institute of Technology. Focusing on health equity, she works at the intersection of HCI, global health, and taboo, particularly in sexual and reproductive health. As a trained menstrual educator, she engages with feminist perspectives to craft just and equitable sociotechnical experiences for all.

Kamala Payyapilly Thiruvengathan is an independent researcher with a PhD in Informatics (HCI) from Penn State University. Her research is situated at the intersection of women's health and technology, aimed at designing for the neglected felt experiences of women navigating pregnancy after loss, with and through technology.

Benedetta Lusi is a Postdoctoral researcher at Erasmus Medical Center, Rotterdam. Her doctoral work, grounded in feminist and relational approaches, focused on designing technology for mental

wellbeing—particularly post-abortion care—envisioning such technology as a space where emotional complexity and contradictions can co-exist.

Adrian Petterson is a PhD candidate at the University of Toronto. They research technology use of abortion access organizations in the United States, and explore possibilities of caring infrastructures for reproductive justice futures. They ground their work in theories of care and reproductive justice as applied to human computer interaction.

Alejandra Gomez Ortega is a Digital Futures Postdoc at Stockholm University. Her research applies critical and feminist perspectives to investigate how we interact with and encounter our data and their algorithmic derivatives through design. She has co-organized creative sessions, workshops, and SIGs on sensitive and intimate topics.

Karthik S. Bhat is an Assistant Professor of Information Science at Drexel University. His research focuses on the design of emerging technologies to support the care work performed by doctors, nurses, community health workers, health aides, and family caregivers.

Sachin R. Pendse is a NIMH T32 Postdoctoral Fellow at the Center for Behavioral Intervention Technologies and an incoming Assistant Professor at the University of California, San Francisco. He studies how marginalization and technology design influence engagements with mental healthcare.

Asra Sakeen Wani is a PhD candidate at IIIT-Delhi, India. Her research engages with communities in conflict-affected regions to examine how contextual realities shape technology use, drawing on critical and feminist perspectives.

Laia Turmo Vidal is a Digital Futures postdoctoral researcher at KTH Royal Institute of Technology. Her work combines body-centric and participatory design approaches to create interactive systems that transform how we perceive and engage with our bodies in health and well-being contexts. She is currently investigating how feminist and crip theories can inform the design of body technologies for sensitive health experiences, such as chronic pain.

Azra Ismail is an Assistant Professor in Biomedical Informatics and Global Health at Emory University, where she leads research on human-centered AI in reproductive health. Drawing from feminist and participatory perspectives, she is deeply invested in fostering more caring, reflexive, and equitable research practices.

Joo Young Park is a PhD candidate at KTH Royal Institute of Technology. Drawing from feminist crip technoscience, she explores tangible on-body interaction to create embodied, non-pathologizing, and tolerant relations between technology and the body. Currently, she is exploring shape-changing touch for (menstrual) pain/discomfort.

Dilisha Patel is a Senior Researcher in Gender and Disability Inclusion at the Global Disability Innovation Hub, University College London. Her research delves into the critical nuances of intersectionality, gender and informing policy that promotes true equity for disabled people. Her previous work has explored marginalised populations and sensitive topics such as fertility and sexuality.

Beyond the core organizing team, this SIG is also supported and endorsed by a broader network of community members who bring additional momentum and insight to the effort, including: Nadia Campo Woytuk (KTH Royal Institute of Technology, Sweden), Vishal Sharma (Georgia Tech, USA), Madeline Balaam (KTH Royal

Institute of Technology, Sweden), and Airi Lampinen (Stockholm University, Sweden).

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